

"If God is male, then male is God" - Discuss

The phrase "If God is male, then male is God" was coined by Mary Daly, summarising her view that the patriarchy is embedded within Christian theology due to the simple conception that God is a male being referred to using the pronoun "he", reinforcing patriarchy by regarding women as the weaker sex and forcing them into roles of submission. On this basis, I will argue in this essay that Daly's critical analysis of Christian theology is convincing as a male representation of God provides the justification for male dominance in society, which is detrimental to gender equality.

Mary Daly's primary argument involved the idea that it is impossible to depatriarchalise the Bible, as feminist theologians have attempted to do, as the Judeo-Christian tradition is inherently anti-feminist. This is because the Bible legitimises a hierarchical society through the dominance of God over humankind; if God is male, this can be (and has been) used as justification for male dominance and the exclusion of women from positions of power. So, a transvaluation of Christianity as a whole is needed in order to overturn the patriarchy as discriminatory ideas are too deeply embedded within the fabric of Christian theology to be salvaged. Daly called this the "castration" of God, calling for the abolition of the word "God" and all associated ideas.

On the other hand, it could be argued that Christianity and the Bible is not in fact innately patriarchal and that the Bible could be interpreted in a feminist light in order to aid the women's liberation movement. Phyllis Tribble denied the apparent conflict between Christianity and feminism, arguing that it is impossible to prescribe an anthropomorphic identity to God despite the use of male pronouns in the Bible. She cited the use of gynomorphic language to describe Yahweh in the Old Testament, such as the adoption of feminine traits as a healer to wounds and nurturing parent (roles exclusive to men in ancient Israel), in order to argue that the nature of God transcends sex. Therefore, it could be argued that the Christian male presentation of God does not necessarily entail patriarchy and is not inherently problematic, as grammatical limitations should not hinder theological understanding.

In spite of this, Tribble's argument is ultimately flawed as it is impossible to interpret the Bible impartially due to the practical implications of the Judeo-Christian framework. Daphne Hampson defended Daly's position, arguing that no matter how much liberal Christians may try to distance themselves from ancient tradition, these attempts will always fail as the value they place on the scripture means that it still impacts their outlook. So, even at a subconscious level, sexist themes prevalent within the Bible such as Paul's instance on female subordination to their husbands and will affect their outlook, and the presentation of a male God will subconsciously

condition them into an acceptance of male dominance. Thus, the Bible should be cast aside entirely in order to achieve women's liberation.

Another key aspect of Daly's argument is that the power which men have been given to define women has cemented their almost God-like dominance over her. This is called the Power of Naming Argument, which asserts that the power of naming demonstrates a power over the named thing, so, as exclusively men have been able to participate in name-giving in the Judeo-Christian tradition, men force women into roles of subordination. She cited that in Genesis 2, God's power to name Adam entailed man's subordination to God, while the fact that Adam was given the power to name the woman Eve cemented her enslavement to him. Therefore, we should arguably reject the ethics and sociology of the Bible as they have given men the divine power to control female autonomy.

However, it could be argued that this is a misinterpretation of the relationship between humans and God based on the modern hierarchical Church which needs to be changed, not the religion itself. For instance, Rosemary Reuther argued that there is no reference to a master-slave relation. The fact that Jesus Christ in his role of the messiah intended to challenge hierarchical structures. The Kingdom of God intended to gain justice for the marginalised, and Jesus' association with prostitutes and the poor demonstrates a commitment to this. So, we must simply reclaim the early Christian commitment to abolishing the master-slave relationship in order to salvage Christianity in the face of a male God.

Daly, however, argued that it is impossible for a male saviour like Jesus to liberate women, as his maleness is part of what makes him the Christian ideal. In this narrative, in order for a woman to be saved she must deny her basic nature and adapt herself to a male oriented standard. This is demonstrated by the fact that in the Church, women can only achieve salvation through men as only male church officials can represent Christ. Therefore, Christianity cannot serve as a means for female liberation as male will always be treated as being naturally closer to God due to their resemblance with Jesus Christ.

In conclusion, the male presentation of God in Christian theology and the implicit power men are given over women means that the argument that "if God is male, then male is God" is convincing as the Bible provides the justification for the subordinate role of women in society in this way.